



A SOOTHEMADE BOOK

Slow Motherhood

*A short manifesto for the mom who is tired of
optimizing.*

Soothemade

A SMALL APOTHECARY · MADE SLOWLY

Dedication

For the mom on a Tuesday at 4pm, choosing the coffee over the laundry.

A note from Maya

This is a short book. Read it in one sitting if you want. Read one chapter at a time if that fits better. Skip the chapters that do not call to you.

I wrote the original version as a four-week paper planner. The planner has fillable pages, a weekly spread, a monthly reflection. People bought it. People also told me they felt bad about not filling it in.

So I wrote this book.

The book is the philosophy without the homework. If the planner is the practice, the book is the permission. Some people need both. Some people just need the permission.

You do not have to perform slow motherhood for anyone. Slow motherhood is a private decision, made in the small moments, often invisible to the people around you.

This book is what that decision looks like.

With care, Maya

Chapter 1: Most Planners Are Productivity Systems for Moms Who Don't Have Time for Productivity Systems

I have bought a lot of planners.

Each one promised that if I could just get the morning routine right, the daily three-things-list right, the weekly review right, the habit tracker right, everything else would fall into place. I would have my time back. I would be calm.

What actually happened: I filled in the planner for four days, abandoned it, felt bad about the abandoned planner, bought a new planner three months later. Repeat for years.

There is a market for what those planners sell. It is mostly people who already feel behind, paying to feel less behind, getting the temporary relief of a fresh blank page, and then feeling more behind when the blank page does not get filled in.

The math does not work. The market exists anyway, because the alternative, accepting that you cannot optimize your way out of an under-supported caregiving load, is harder than buying another planner.

Slow motherhood is the alternative.

It is not anti-planning. It is not anti-systems. It is the recognition that the size of your daily list is bigger than the day, and that no system will close that gap. Your day will end with things undone. That is not a system problem. That is the math.

The work of slow motherhood is making peace with the math.

Chapter 2: A Note on "Slow"

A friend asked me what "slow motherhood" means. Here is what I said.

It is not a Sunday in a sunbeam with a clean linen apron and a sourdough loaf.

It is a Tuesday at 4pm when the laundry is still in the dryer and the baby is finally asleep and I have to choose between sitting with my coffee for four minutes or starting dinner, and I pick the coffee.

That is slow motherhood. The four minutes you choose yourself, when there is an equally valid case for the laundry.

Some weeks you will pick the laundry every time. That is okay too. Slow is not a rule. It is a permission.

This book is the permission, written down.

Chapter 3: What It Actually Looks Like

Slow motherhood, on a regular weekday, looks like this.

You wake up. The baby is already crying. You feed them. The dishes are still in the sink from last night. You ignore the dishes for now. You make coffee. You take the first sip while the baby is on your chest.

That sip is slow motherhood.

You will get to the dishes later, or not. Both are fine. The performance of "got the dishes done before 8am" is not what makes you a good mom. The first sip of coffee while the baby breathed against your chest is what you will remember.

Slow motherhood is choosing the rememberable thing.

Sometimes the rememberable thing is the dishes. The kitchen is calm and the kid is napping and you fold the towels with the window open and the radio low. That is also slow motherhood. The presence of the act is what makes it slow, not whether it is "useful."

Fast motherhood looks productive on the surface. Two loads of laundry, three meals prepped, four errands run, the kid bathed by 6pm. Then a partner gets home and asks how the day was, and the only honest answer is "I do not remember it."

The day was not remembered because nothing in it was paid attention to. The productivity was the substitute for presence.

Slow motherhood is the opposite trade. Fewer items checked. More moments noticed.

Chapter 4: Use This Badly

The original printable planner had a phrase on the second page: *use it badly*.

Most people did not know what to do with that.

Here is what it means.

Use the planner on the days you remember. Skip it on the days you do not. Write in pen. Cross things out. Tape a photo on a blank page. Doodle in the margins. Leave a week blank. Fold a corner. Spill coffee.

The planner is not testing you. The planner is a surface for you to make marks on if marks are useful that day.

This book is the same. The chapters are an offering, not an assignment. Skim the ones that do not land. Re-read the ones that do. Write notes in the margins if you have a physical copy. Highlight a sentence on Kindle if you have the ebook.

You are not being graded on your engagement with this book. The book does not care.

What matters is whether one sentence in here ends up tucked into your back pocket for a hard day. If one sentence does, the book did its job.

Chapter 5: One Word

A small exercise. Five minutes, maybe.

If this season of motherhood had a single word, not the word you should pick, the word you would pick if no one was reading, what is the word?

Write it down somewhere. The first page of a notebook. The notes app. A post-it stuck to the inside of a cabinet door.

The word is for you, not for me. You do not have to share it.

The word changes. The word in the first month postpartum is different from the word at six months. The word in your first pregnancy is different from the word in your fourth toddler year. Re-do the exercise periodically. The word that comes up is the word.

Some words that have come up for people who did this exercise:

- *Drowning*. A real season. Not a metaphor.
- *Tender*. The opposite season. The one where everything is sharp because the love is new.
- *Tired*. Most common. Always true.
- *Saturated*. A different kind of tired. The "I have absorbed all I can absorb" kind.
- *Becoming*. The hopeful one. The one where you can feel a version of yourself emerging.
- *Lost*. The honest one. The one no one tells you it is okay to say out loud.

Your word is yours. Write it. Return to it.

Chapter 6: What You Actually Want

Another five-minute exercise. The opposite of a vision board.

Not the goals you should have. Not the things on Pinterest. Not the postpartum body, not the curated nursery, not the smiling Instagram photo with the eucalyptus garland.

Just one thing you wish were true about your day-to-day in four weeks that is not true right now.

Some examples that have come up:

- *I want one shower a day, uninterrupted.*
- *I want to have read a real book by then.*
- *I want to have eaten one meal sitting down at a table.*
- *I want my partner to do bath time twice a week, on his own, without asking me what to do.*
- *I want to have texted my best friend back.*
- *I want to have stopped scrolling at midnight.*

The wants are small on purpose. Small things are the ones that actually change.

Pick one. Write it down. In four weeks, see if it became true. If it did not, that is also information. The want may need help: the partner conversation, the babysitter, the calendar block. Or it may need to wait. Both are real.



Chapter 7: What You Can Let Go Of

The hardest exercise.

One thing you are doing because you "should," not because it is working for you.

A permission slip, signed by you, to drop it for the next four weeks.

Examples:

- *The pediatrician-recommended nap schedule the baby will not follow.*
- *The complicated dinner you make on Thursdays because someone on Instagram said.*
- *The thank-you notes from the baby shower that you have been meaning to write for six months.*
- *The friendship that has been one-sided for two years.*
- *The mother-in-law's expectation that you call her every Sunday.*
- *The unread book stack growing on your bedside table.*

Pick one. Drop it for four weeks. See if anything actually fell apart.

The result, almost always, is that nothing fell apart. The thing you were forcing yourself to do, that you stopped doing, mostly did not register with anyone. You were the only one keeping that score.

After four weeks, decide if you want to pick it back up. Most of the time, you will not.

Chapter 8: One Small Yes

For each thing you let go of, plant one small yes.

A small thing that brought you joy in the last seven days, even if it lasted 30 seconds. Notice it. Plan one of these for this week.

The smaller, the better.

- *The first cup of coffee in the morning, sitting down.*
- *The walk around the block at sunset.*
- *The shower with the water as hot as you can stand it.*
- *The fifteen minutes of reading before bed.*
- *The five-minute phone call with a specific friend who makes you laugh.*
- *The slow, deliberate brushing of your kid's hair.*

The trick is the planning. The small yes is unlikely to happen on its own. You have to schedule it. Put it in the calendar. Tell your partner. Treat it as a real thing, with a real time, that you do not move for an "urgent" thing that is not actually urgent.

The compounding effect of one small yes per week is enormous. By the end of a year, you have collected fifty-two moments of yourself.

Chapter 9: The Monthly Check-In

The fastest review of the month you can do is two questions.

Where did I find two minutes of myself this month? Not five-star vacations. Two minutes. The bath that ran a little longer. The car ride alone where the radio was off. The morning the partner took the kid out for a walk and you sat in the kitchen.

Name three. Write them down. They count.

What is the thing I am tired of pretending? This is the harder question. The pretending costs you energy. The pretending might be small ("I am fine"). The pretending might be large ("my marriage is okay"). The pretending might be specific ("I do not mind that my mother-in-law gives me parenting advice").

Naming the pretending is the start of changing it.

That is the whole check-in. Five minutes.

You can do it on the last day of the month. The first day of the next month. Whenever you remember.

If you do it once and never again, that is still the right amount.

Chapter 10: A Final Letter

If you read this in four weeks and feel like you "failed" the book, here is what I would want to tell you now.

The book is not a homework set.

The point is not to do the exercises. The point is to spend a little time with the idea that you are allowed to want less, do less, perform less, prove less. The idea is the gift, not the practice.

If the only thing that stuck with you was the Tuesday-at-4pm vignette, that is enough.

If the only thing that stuck with you was the permission to use the planner badly, that is enough.

If you do not remember reading the book at all in three months but you find yourself, on a hard afternoon, sitting down with a coffee instead of doing the next thing on the list, the book worked.

Slow motherhood does not require knowing it is happening. It just requires the moments. The moments are yours.

With care, Maya

About Soothemade

Soothemade is a small apothecary of printables, planners, cards, and books for new parents.

The printable companion to this book is the **Slow Motherhood Weekly Planner** at notes.soothemade.com, a 4-week undated planner you can use badly.

Also from Soothemade

- **The Asking for Help Script Pack**, for the help that makes slow motherhood possible.
 - **30 Scripts for the Postpartum Visitor**, for the boundaries that make slow motherhood possible.
 - **The Mom Rage Workbook** (printable), for the days that are not slow.
 - **The Newborn Survival Planner** (printable), for the season before slow.
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Crisis lines

If "slow" is not the word for your season, and what is happening is closer to the edge.

United States

- 988, Suicide and Crisis Lifeline
- 1-833-852-6262, Postpartum Support International
- 1-833-943-5746, Maternal Mental Health Hotline

United Kingdom

- 116 123, Samaritans

Canada

- 9-8-8, Suicide Crisis Helpline

Australia

- 13 11 14, Lifeline

A Soothemade book. Made slowly, in plain language.